

Selection pressure turns a routine season into meaningful audit

With senior players away on national duty, the tournament becomes less a showcase of star power and more a **scrutiny** of India's bench strength, from seam bowling all rounders to power hitters.

Selection heat:

For Riyan Parag, the SMAT is another chance to push his upward arc. His power-hitting and growing all-round value keep him firmly in the conversation for franchises and national selectors.

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The Syed Mushtaq Ali Trophy (SMAT) domestic T20 competition has closely mirrored the evolution and demands of its more glamorous cousin, the Indian Premier League (IPL). Its latest iteration, beginning on November 26, will also serve as a timely audition for the IPL auction scheduled for December 16. By that time, teams progressing out of the group stage and into the Super League would have played nine matches, giving scouts ample game time to assess players, unlike last year when the IPL auction took place after just one round of SMAT.

"SMAT definitely has a place in the auction. Any IPL will be won by a team that has a strong Indian core," renowned coach and Kolkata Knight Riders scout, Biju George, tells Sportstar.

The Indian domestic cricket schedule now reflects the rigours of international cricket. After five rounds of gruelling four-day Ranji Trophy cricket, players will have just a week to brace for high-tempo T20 action. Like the Ranji Trophy, the Elite (32 teams) and Plate (six teams) divisions have been introduced